

TYPOGRAPHY · WORKING NOTE

The default document

Why generated PDFs all look alike, and the three decisions that stop it happening.

Every document produced without a design decision converges on the same artefact. Not because the tool is limited, but because a default is what you get when nobody chooses. The result is recognisable at a glance: a centred bold title, an unbroken ladder of headings, bullets standing in for sentences, one saturated blue doing all the accent work.

The fix is not more effort per document. It is making the choice explicit and making it *vary*. Three decisions carry nearly all the weight.

1. Decide what the reader does

A memo is read once, standing up, to reach a decision. A manual is read with both hands busy. A report is studied. These are different objects, and they should not share a layout. Pick the archetype before picking anything visual, because everything downstream follows from it.

2. Set the measure, not the margin

The most common failure in generated documents is a text column running the full width of the page. Sixty to seventy-five characters is the readable range; a full A4 measure is closer to a hundred and ten. The correction is to narrow the column, not to widen the margins - the leftover space then becomes useful, somewhere for sidenotes, figures and running heads to live.

Space above a heading, not below it. A heading belongs to the text that follows, and the whitespace should say so.

3. Choose two faces and three sizes

One text face, one display face, and no more than three sizes will carry any document. The discipline is in refusing the fourth size and the second accent colour. Hierarchy comes from weight, space

The tell is uniformity. Real documents differ because their readers differ - a runbook and a board memo have almost nothing in common.

This page uses a 110mm column inside a 166mm content area. The remainder is not waste; it is where this note is sitting.

and position long before it comes from scale - and a document that signals hierarchy with size alone reads as an outline rather than a piece of writing.

The failure worth knowing about

In this rendering pipeline, a font that fails to load does not raise an error. It silently falls back to Times New Roman, and the document still renders, still looks plausible, and is quietly wrong. Three causes account for nearly all of it: a variable font, which cannot be embedded at all; a remote stylesheet, which is never fetched; and a multi-word family name left unquoted in CSS, which can invalidate the whole declaration.

Each of these produces the same symptom and none of them announces itself. That is the argument for checking the output rather than assuming it - the difference between a document that was designed and one that merely rendered.

Verify rather than trust: inspecting the embedded faces of the finished PDF takes a second and catches all three.